TIME TO CHOOSE OUR HEROES WISELY



AMISH

A quiet but significant debate has been reignited following the release of the film *Chhaava*—should India continue to preserve the tomb of Emperor Aurangzeb who history unequivocally remembers as a cruel, repressive and sectarian ruler? Expectedly, the debate is heated and polarised.

In my recent podcast episode of 'Immortal India', I attempted a calm, respectful and honest approach on the issue. I attempt it now in the written format.

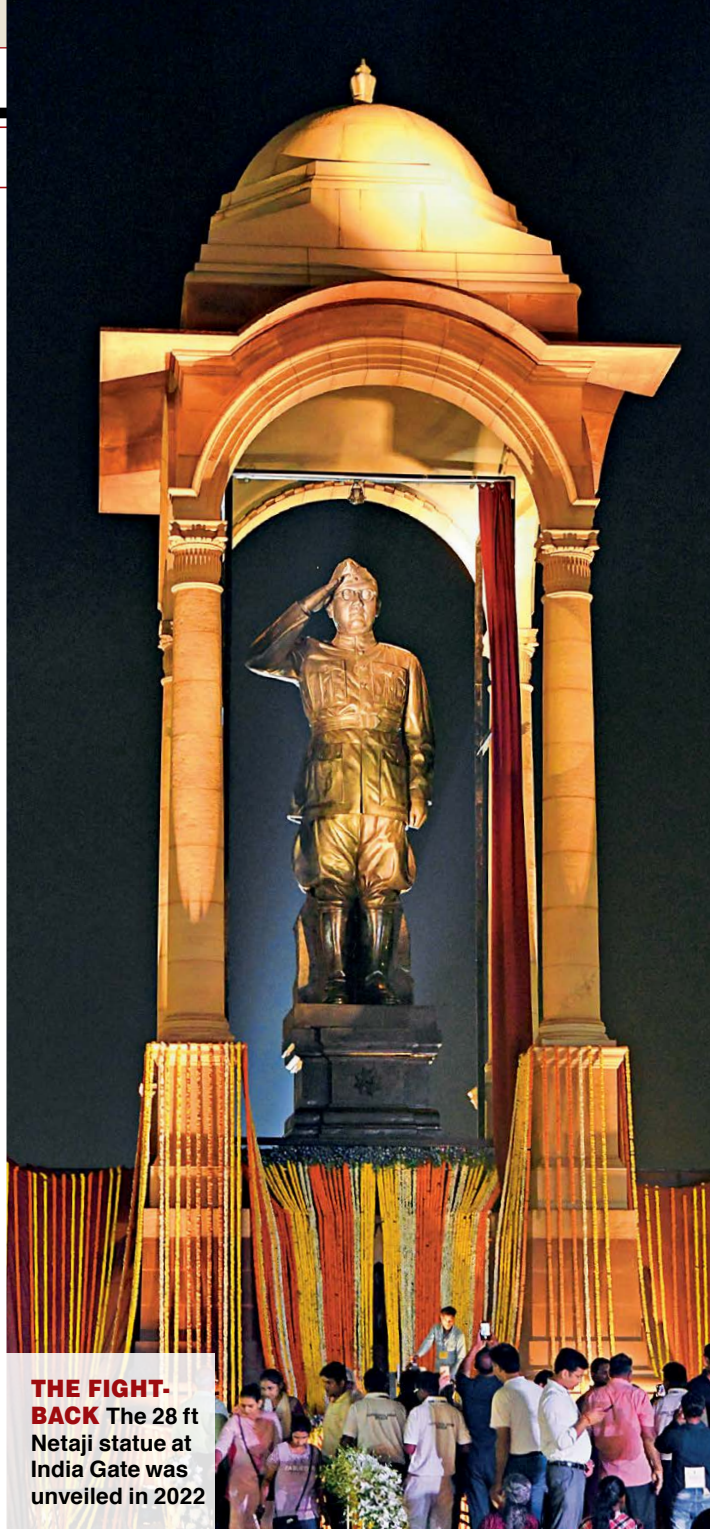
Firstly, a clear statement: no culture with any sense of self-respect or a desire to survive glorifies its historical oppressors. France does not have memorials celebrating the Nazi invaders. Israel does not name parks after Hitler. These are not acts of erasing history but of self-respect. Memories of such oppressors remain in books and museums—where they belong—not in ceremonial public spaces.

India has witnessed horrific invasions and centuries of subjugation. From the Turkic Delhi Sultans to the Timurid Mughals to the British, we have seen wave after wave of foreign domination. Yes, they left their mark. I write this very column in English, after all. Our architecture, cuisine, administrative systems—all bear traces of these past rulers. But acknowledging their influence is different from celebrating them. The former is history. The latter is absurdity.

Imagine this: a family repeatedly brutalised by outsiders later lovingly preserves the portraits of their tormentors in their homes. Ridiculous, right? Or perhaps an internalised inferiority complex?

We are not that family. We should not be.

India has been shaped by many forces—both noble and ignoble. But let us be honest in recognising the duality of major historical crimes in our land. The first was the brutal violence unleashed by foreign invaders—Turkic (who were Muslim), and British (who were Christian). The second was the internal oppression of our backward and Dalit communities by upper castes. Both have wounded our civilisation deeply. And both must be remembered, mourned, and healed from.



ANI

THE FIGHT-BACK The 28 ft Netaji statue at India Gate was unveiled in 2022

Yet, a curiously damaging hypocrisy has emerged in modern India. The Left-liberal discourse rightly demands a confrontation with the second crime—caste-based oppression—and insists on social justice through reservations and dialogue. We have seen progress—India's first full-term OBC prime minister, and a president from a Scheduled Tribe background. These are signs of movement in the right direction, even if we have further to go.

But the same Left-liberal voices often counsel silence on the first crime. They say, "Let's not talk about the violence